MERCY'S ANATOMY

Season 2, Episode 10

"Much Too Much"

Episode 2x10. The counterpart of *Grey's Anatomy* 2x10. Narrator: Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock

In-story dates: Thursday, December 1, 2005, 5:41 AM through 11:58 PM

Script: Cold Open + 5 Acts + Tag. 41 scenes. Standard: MA-009

Depends on MA-001 through MA-011 and episodes 1x01-2x09

EPISODE PDF PACKAGE (MA-009 §6): 1. Title page and cast (with ages on Thursday, December 1, 2005). 2. Script. 3. Media Companion. 4. Continuity Sheet.

Cast in Order of Appearance (Ages on Thursday, December 1, 2005)

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Howard Divine	Harmony's father; MTA Q4 bus operator	Aug 30, 1950	55
Miss Odell Brightwater (new)	Q4 passenger	Apr 22, 1927	78
Raymond 'Big Ray' Toles	Chief of Security	Jan 1, 1960	45
Dr. Constance Albritton (new)	Joint Commission physician surveyor	Sep 8, 1946	59
Gerald Mayfield, RN (new)	Joint Commission nurse surveyor	May 19, 1954	51
Dolores Haskins (new)	Joint Commission administrator surveyor	Jan 27, 1959	46
Dr. Horace Whitlow	Chief of Medicine	Sep 19, 1949	56
Dr. Natasha Donohue	Chief of Surgery	Jun 2, 1958	47
Franklin Bassett, Esq.	General Counsel	Oct 28, 1958	47
Bernadette 'Bernie' Watkins	Executive Assistant to the Chief	Jun 6, 1950	55
Dr. Arianna Cummings	Surgical Intern (Step 2 CK retake December 12)	Oct 25, 1979	26
Dr. Raven Ellison	Surgical Intern (26 on Saturday)	Dec 3, 1979	25
Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock	Surgical Intern (narrator)	Jan 5, 1979	26
Dr. Harmony Divine	Surgical Intern	Jun 19, 1979	26
Dr. Amond Baker	Surgical Intern	Feb 10, 1979	26
Dr. Esther Smilley	Surgical Intern	Sep 20, 1979	26
Dr. Bryce Kennerly	Surgical Intern (on probation)	Jun 11, 1978	27
Dr. Elxa Bullock	Surgical Resident (30 weeks pregnant)	Aug 29, 1977	28
Dr. Abraham Lowery	Attending General Surgeon	Jan 9, 1947	58
Jermaine 'Jaws' Biggs (new)	Patient: acute gastric dilatation, perforation	Aug 20, 1978	27
Annette Biggs (new)	Jermaine's mother; corrections officer	Nov 3, 1953	52
Ambrose Tate (new)	Patient: digoxin toxicity; retired Pullman porter	Jul 4, 1926	79
Celestine Tate-Moore (new)	Ambrose's daughter; bank manager	Oct 18, 1955	50
Dr. Philip Grant	Medicine Resident	Mar 13, 1976	29
Geraldine Toomer (new)	Patient: 41-lb ovarian mucinous cystadenoma	Jun 25, 1953	52
Dr. Clayton Hartwell	OB/GYN and Fetal Surgeon	Mar 3, 1971	34
Dr. Camille Toussaint	Orthopedic Resident	Jul 21, 1976	29
Augustin Toussaint	Camille's father	Feb 9, 1941	64
Lamont 'Monty' Gaines	Owner, Monty's on Jackson	Oct 10, 1962	43

Character	Role in this episode	Born	Age
Cedric Hall	Architect; Monty's partner	Jan 22, 1965	40
Russell Jeffries	Elxa's husband; chemistry teacher	Apr 3, 1975	30
Dr. Robert Bullock	Chief of Cardiothoracic Surgery	Feb 10, 1956	49

Also appearing: the QGH CEO, the Chief Nursing Officer, the surgical program director, a CT radiologist, two anesthesiologists, scrub and circulating nurses, a recovery nurse, and a teenage cast patient and his mother. Mentioned: Rosa Parks, Lorna Ellison (by card), Victor Donohue, Dr. Okafor (Mr. Tate's Harlem cardiologist), Sister Patterson, Corinne Smilley, Malcolm Sloan, Lillian Divine and Dr. Paulette Greenidge.

COLD OPEN

1 INT. MTA Q4 BUS - LINDEN BOULEVARD, CAMBRIA HEIGHTS - PRE-DAWN
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 5:41 AM

An empty city bus idling at the first stop of the morning, its interior lights harsh in the dark. Howard Divine (55), in his MTA operator's jacket, takes a strip of black satin ribbon out of his lunch bag and ties it carefully across the first forward-facing seat behind him. He smooths the bow. He coughs, deep and wet, into his elbow.

The doors hiss open. MISS ODELL BRIGHTWATER (78), in a wool coat and a church hat, climbs aboard with a cane and taps her MetroCard. She sees the ribbon and stops.

MISS ODELL
(beat)
What's this, Howard?

HOWARD
(quietly)
Fifty years ago today, Miss Odell. (beat) Montgomery. The Cleveland Avenue bus.

Miss Odell looks at the ribbon for a long moment. Then she walks past it, takes a seat two rows back and folds her hands on her cane.

MISS ODELL
(beat)
Nobody sits there today. (beat) Drive, baby.

MARC (V.O.)
A surgeon learns very early that there's such a thing as too much.

Howard pulls away from the curb. In his rearview mirror, the black ribbon sways on the empty seat.

MARC (V.O.)
Too much blood. Too much pressure. Too much medicine.

2 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MAIN LOBBY - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 6:58 AM

The lobby at shift change. Big Ray Toles (45), Chief of Security, sits behind the front desk with a coffee. The revolving door turns. Three people come through in a precise, unhurried line, with rolling briefcases and identical lanyards.

DR. CONSTANCE ALBRITTON (59), a physician surveyor with silver locs and half-moon glasses. GERALD MAYFIELD, RN (51), a nurse surveyor in a sweater vest, already making notes. DOLORES HASKINS (46), the administrator surveyor, holding a binder.

DR. ALBRITTON
(pleasant, setting a card on the desk)
Good morning. (beat) We're from The Joint Commission. (beat) We'll need to see the CEO and the Chief of Surgery.

Big Ray reads the card. He sets down his coffee very slowly.

BIG RAY
(beat)
Yes, ma'am. (beat) One moment.

He picks up the desk phone and dials.

BIG RAY
(into the phone, low)
Bernie. (beat) It's Ray. (beat) They're here.

MARC (V.O.)
And we learn that the most dangerous moment for any patient...

In the mezzanine above, half hidden behind a pillar, Whitlow (56) watches the three surveyors with his tea cup in his hand. He smiles.

MARC (V.O.)
...is when somebody's sure they know exactly how much it can take.

END OF COLD OPEN

ACT ONE

3 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF'S OFFICE - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 7:09 AM

Natasha (47), in a navy suit and pearls, sits across from Dr. Albritton at the conference table. Bassett (47) and Bernie (55) sit beside her. Mayfield and Haskins take notes.

DR. ALBRITTON
This is a for-cause, unannounced survey, Dr. Donohue, in response to a complaint. (beat) We'll use tracer methodology. We'll pick patients and follow their care through the building: every handoff, every chart, every person who touched them. (beat) We'll interview staff at random. Residents. Nurses. Housekeeping.

NATASHA
(calm)
Of course. (beat) Bernie has a conference room ready for you, and every record you ask for will be delivered within the hour. (beat) Including the files of my son.

Albritton looks up over her glasses.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
You're aware that's the subject of the complaint.

NATASHA
(beat)
I'm aware, Dr. Albritton. (beat) I'm also aware that you didn't come here to take my word for anything. (beat) So look anywhere you like.

BASSETT
(smoothly, sliding a binder across)
Every case Dr. Bullock has scrubbed since July first. Attestations. Evaluations. The service firewall memo of November ninth.

DR. ALBRITTON
(opening it, beat)
You did this before we arrived.

NATASHA
(beat)
I did it before you were invited.

Albritton closes the binder and studies Natasha for a long beat.

DR. ALBRITTON
(standing)
We'll start on the floors.

4 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - INTERNS' LOCKER ROOM - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 7:16 AM

The interns change in a state of quiet panic. Arianna (26) sits on the bench with the flashcards, gray-faced, eyes red from too little sleep. Raven (25) watches her. Marc (26), Harmony (26), Amond (26) and Esther (26). Kennerly (27) at the end of the bench.

HARMONY
(pulling on her scrub top)
Three of them. Big Ray said the doctor has locs and "the eyes of a Baptist deaconess."

AMOND
(dry)
So we're dead.

ESTHER
(to Marc)
Are you okay?

MARC
(beat)
I'm the reason they're here. (beat) I'm great.

RAVEN
(to Arianna)
How many hours did you sleep?

ARIANNA
(not looking up)
Enough.

RAVEN
How many?

ARIANNA
(beat)
Three. (beat) It's eleven days, Raven. Eleven days, and I'm still missing renal.

RAVEN
(taking the cards gently from her hands)
You're not missing renal. You're missing sleep. (beat) These are mine until lunch.

ARIANNA
(beat, reaching)
Give them back.

RAVEN
(putting them in her own locker and spinning the dial)
Happy early birthday to me.

Arianna stares at the locked locker. Kennerly, at the end of the bench, has been listening to everything. He stands, closes his locker and leaves without a word.

5 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - NURSES' STATION - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 7:27 AM

Elxa (28), thirty weeks pregnant, her belly now enormous, sits on the stool with her feet up on a box of gloves. Lowery (58) stands beside her. The interns gather.

ELXA
The Joint Commission is in the building. (beat) Here's what that means. (beat) You do everything exactly the way you're supposed to do it, every time. (beat) Time-outs before every incision. Hand hygiene in and out of every room. Signed orders. Dated orders. Timed orders. (beat) If a surveyor asks you a question and you don't know the answer, you say, "I don't know, but here's how I'd find out." (beat) You do not guess. You do not lie. You do not be interesting.

LOWERY
(gently)
They aren't the enemy. (beat) They're just a mirror. (beat) Show them a good face.

ELXA
Bullock, Smilley: Lowery.
Ellison: Gyn, with Dr. Hartwell.
(beat) Divine: Ortho. Baker:
Medicine, cardiology consults.
Cummings: me. (beat) Kennerly:
ER. (beat) Go.

The interns move. Elxa winces and shifts on the stool. Lowery glances at her.

LOWERY
(low)
Thirty weeks.

ELXA
(beat)
Thirty weeks, Abraham. And my first Lamaze class is Monday. (beat) Don't look at me like that.

LOWERY
(beat)
Like what?

ELXA
Like I'm a patient.

6 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EMERGENCY DEPARTMENT - BAY 6 - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 7:51 AM

JERMAINE "JAWS" BIGGS (27), a big, round-faced man in a T-shirt that reads "JAWS OF JAMAICA -- 2005 WING KING," lies on the gurney, groaning, his belly hugely distended and drum-tight. His mother, MRS. ANNETTE BIGGS (52), a corrections officer in uniform, stands beside him with her arms crossed. Lowery, Marc and Esther are at the bedside.

ANNETTE
(furious)
The Sutphin Boulevard Wing Showdown. (beat) Last night. Eleven o'clock. (beat) He ate one hundred and seventy-three chicken wings in twelve minutes, then drank a gallon of iced tea and came home and threw up on my couch.

JERMAINE
(groaning)
One seventy-four, Ma. (beat) They didn't count the last one.

MARC
(palpating gently)
Mr. Biggs, when did you last throw up?

JERMAINE
(beat)
Midnight. (beat) Then I couldn't anymore. I tried. (beat) Nothing would come up.

Marc and Lowery exchange a look. Esther slides the stethoscope over the belly.

ESTHER
(beat)
Tympanic. High-pitched. (beat) Then nothing.

MARC
(to Lowery)
Acute gastric dilatation. He overloaded his stomach until the wall stretched and the outlet kinked. (beat) He can't vomit, he can't empty it. (beat) If the pressure gets too high, the wall loses its blood supply.

LOWERY
(beat)
And then?

MARC
(beat)
Then it dies. (beat) Then it ruptures.

LOWERY
(calm)
NG tube. Big bore. Now. (beat) Labs, lactate, upright film, CT if he'll fit.

Marc slides the nasogastric tube in. A beat. Then the canister on the wall begins to fill with brown fluid, one liter, two, three. Jermaine sags with relief.

JERMAINE
(beat)
Oh, God. (beat) Oh, thank you, Jesus.

ANNETTE
(beat, softening)
Is he going to be okay?

LOWERY
(watching the canister)
Ask me after the CT, Mrs. Biggs.

Behind the curtain, Gerald Mayfield, RN, the nurse surveyor, writes something on his clipboard.

7 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MEDICINE FLOOR - ROOM 714 - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 8:14 AM

A double room on Whitlow's Medicine floor. MR. AMBROSE TATE (79), a retired Pullman porter, gaunt and confused, sits slumped in his bed, picking at the sheet. His daughter, CELESTINE TATE-MOORE (50), a bank manager, is beside him. Dr. Philip Grant (29), the medicine resident, stands with Amond, who has been called down from

cardiology.

DR. GRANT
Admitted Tuesday for confusion and a fall. (beat) Heart rate thirty-eight this morning. We think it's sick sinus, so we called you for a pacemaker evaluation.

Amond looks at the monitor, then at the old man.

AMOND
(kneeling by the bed)
Mr. Tate. (beat) How are you feeling, sir?

AMBROSE
(vague)
Sick to my stomach. (beat) And everything's yellow. (beat) The lights. Your face. (beat) Like the sun's gone down wrong.

Amond goes very still.

AMOND
(beat, to Dr. Grant)
Yellow vision. (beat) Nausea, confusion, bradycardia. (beat) What's his digoxin level?

DR. GRANT
(beat)
We started him on digoxin Tuesday night for his atrial fibrillation. (beat) Point-one-two-five. Standard dose.

CELESTINE
(frowning)
He already takes digoxin. (beat) Dr. Okafor in Harlem has had him on it for nine years. Point-two-five. I bring him his pill box every morning. (beat) I told the nurse in the ER on Tuesday. I wrote it down for her.

A terrible silence. Dr. Grant opens the chart, flipping pages, faster and faster.

AMOND
(quietly)
Mr. Tate's been getting double digoxin for two days. (beat) Draw a level, stat. (beat) Get potassium. (beat) And call pharmacy for Digibind.

In the doorway, unnoticed, Gerald Mayfield stops writing.

8 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - GYNECOLOGY CLINIC - EXAM ROOM 3 - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 8:42 AM

MS. GERALDINE TOOMER (52), the organist at Greater Allen A.M.E. in Jamaica, sits on the exam table in a gown with a tent-sized hospital blanket across her lap. Her abdomen is enormous, as round and tight as a woman carrying triplets at term. Clayton (34) and Raven study the CT on the light box.

CLAYTON
(gently)
Ms. Toomer. When did you first notice the swelling?

GERALDINE
(ashamed, not meeting their eyes)
Two years ago. (beat) I thought it was the change. I thought I was getting fat. (beat) I went up a dress size every few months. (beat) The ladies at church started making comments. So I stopped going to the fellowship dinners.

RAVEN
(softly)
Have you been able to see your feet?

GERALDINE
(beat, tears rising)
Not since last Easter.

Raven looks at the CT. A single enormous cyst with septations fills the entire abdomen from the pelvis to the diaphragm.

CLAYTON
(to Raven)
Size?

RAVEN
(beat)
Thirty-four by twenty-nine centimeters. (beat) Multiloculated. Ovarian origin. (beat) No ascites, no nodularity, normal CA-125. (beat) Most likely a mucinous cystadenoma.

CLAYTON
Benign?

RAVEN
(beat)
Most likely benign. (beat) We won't know until pathology.

GERALDINE
(barely)
Is it a baby? (beat) The ladies said I must be hiding a baby.

CLAYTON
(sitting beside her, warmly)
It's not a baby, Ms. Toomer. (beat) It's a tumor that grew from your ovary. It's probably not cancer. (beat) It probably weighs forty pounds. (beat) And tomorrow morning you're going to see your feet.

Geraldine covers her face and weeps. Raven puts a hand on her back.

9 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF OF MEDICINE'S OFFICE - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 9:08 AM

Whitlow pours tea from his gold-rimmed set, humming. A knock. Dr. Grant stands in the doorway, white-faced, holding a chart.

WHITLOW
(not looking up)
Dr. Grant. (beat) Shouldn't you be on the floor? We have guests.

DR. GRANT
(barely)
Dr. Whitlow. (beat) Mr. Tate in 714. (beat) He was on home digoxin. His daughter told the ER nurse. It never made it to our admission orders. (beat) I started him on digoxin on top of it Tuesday night.

Whitlow sets down the teapot.

DR. GRANT
(beat)
His level is four-point-one. (beat) Dr. Baker from surgery caught it. (beat) He's getting Digibind now.

WHITLOW
(beat, carefully)
Is he stable?

DR. GRANT
(beat)
He will be. (beat) Sir. (beat) The nurse surveyor was in the doorway when Baker asked for the level. (beat) He asked me for the medication reconciliation form.

WHITLOW
(very quiet)
And?

DR. GRANT
(beat)
We don't have one, sir. (beat) We were supposed to have it in place this year. National Patient Safety Goal eight. (beat) We were going to have it done by January.

Whitlow stands motionless, the teacup in his hand. The tea goes cold.

10 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - RADIOLOGY - CT READING ROOM - MORNING
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 9:31 AM

Lowery, Marc and Esther behind the radiologist. On the screen: Jermaine's stomach, decompressed but abnormal. Its wall is thin and gray, with gas bubbles inside the wall itself, and a small pocket of free air above the liver.

RADIOLOGIST
(quietly)
Pneumatosis of the gastric wall along the greater curvature. (beat) And free air. (beat) It's perforated.

ESTHER
(beat)
The NG came too late.

LOWERY
(beat)
The NG came at seven-fifty. (beat) His stomach started dying at midnight on his mother's couch. (beat) Book the OR.

The door opens. Dr. Albritton steps in, her lanyard visible, holding a slim folder.

DR. ALBRITTON
(pleasant)
Dr. Lowery. Dr. Bullock. (beat) Dr. Smilley, I believe.

They all turn.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
We're going to trace Mr. Biggs's care today. (beat) From the ER through the OR to recovery. (beat) I'll be observing the procedure from the gallery.

Marc looks at Lowery. Lowery doesn't blink.

LOWERY
(evenly)
You're very welcome, Doctor. (beat) Dr. Bullock will be first assist.

Albritton writes one word in her folder. Marc can't see what it is.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

11 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 4 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 10:12 AM

Jermaine, intubated and draped. Above in the gallery, alone behind the glass, Dr. Albritton sits with her folder. Lowery, Marc and Esther stand at the table, gowned, with the scrub nurse, the circulator and the anesthesiologist.

CIRCULATOR
(reading from the clipboard)
Time-out. (beat) Patient: Jermaine Biggs. Date of birth August 20, 1978. (beat) Procedure: exploratory laparotomy, possible partial gastrectomy. (beat) Consent signed. Antibiotics given at nine-fifty-eight. No allergies. (beat) Site: abdomen, midline.

MARC
(clearly)
Agreed.

LOWERY
Agreed.

ESTHER
Agreed.

ANESTHESIOLOGIST
Agreed.

Lowery hands Marc the scalpel. Above, Albritton leans forward.

LOWERY
(calm)
Dr. Bullock. Midline. Xiphoid to umbilicus.

Marc makes a long, clean incision. Electrocautery through the fascia. The peritoneum opens. A gush of murky fluid and the smell of chicken wings and bile. Esther suctions.

MARC
(focused)
Spillage, all four quadrants. (beat) There. (beat) Greater curvature. A ten-centimeter segment of necrosis, black. (beat) A two-centimeter perforation at the center. (beat) The rest of the stomach is pink. The short gastrics are pulsing.

LOWERY
(beat)
Plan?

MARC
(beat)
Wedge resection of the necrotic segment with a linear stapler, to bleeding margins. (beat) Check the fundus and the posterior wall through the lesser sac. Washout, at least six liters. (beat) Then a feeding jejunostomy, because he won't be eating chicken wings, or anything else, for a while.

LOWERY
(beat, to the scrub nurse)
GIA eighty. (beat) Give it to Dr. Bullock.

Marc fires. Once, twice, three times. Each staple line is perfect. Lowery barely touches an instrument. Above, Albritton watches, and her pen doesn't move.

LOWERY
(low, eyes on the field)
She's watching your hands, Marc. (beat) Not your last name.

MARC
(beat)
I know.

LOWERY
(beat)
So give her nothing else to look at.

12 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MEDICINE FLOOR - ROOM 714 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 10:36 AM

Ambrose Tate, on the monitor. The Digibind infusion runs into his arm. Amond watches the heart rate climb: forty-two, forty-eight, fifty-six. Celestine holds her father's hand. Gerald Mayfield stands quietly in the corner.

AMOND
(to Celestine)
The antibody binds the digoxin in his blood so his body can clear it. (beat) His heart rate's coming up. (beat) In a few hours, the yellow should fade.

AMBROSE
(blinking, clearer)
Young man. (beat) Your face isn't yellow anymore. (beat) It's brown.

AMOND
(beat, smiling)
That's the right color, Mr. Tate.

AMBROSE
(beat)
I carried bags for forty-one years on the Twentieth Century Limited and the Broadway Limited. (beat) You know what I learned? (beat) Too many hands on one man's bag, and somebody always leaves it on the platform.

Mayfield, in the corner, writes that down. Then he steps forward.

MAYFIELD
(to Amond, politely)
Dr. Baker. You're a surgical intern. (beat) How did you know to ask about home medications?

AMOND
(beat)
Because he told me the lights were yellow, sir. (beat) Digoxin toxicity causes xanthopsia. (beat) And because my mother is Harriet Baker-Fenwick of Baldwin Hills. (beat) She made me recite every pill in my grandmother's cabinet every Sunday when I was ten. (beat) The pills you don't know about are the ones that kill people.

Mayfield looks at him for a beat. Then he nods once.

MAYFIELD
(beat)
Thank you, Doctor.

13 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ORTHOPEDICS - CAST ROOM - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 10:58 AM

Camille (29) wraps a fiberglass cast around a teenage boy's forearm while Harmony holds the arm in position. Camille's cell phone buzzes in her scrub pocket. She glances at it. "PAPA." She doesn't answer. It buzzes again. Then again.

HARMONY
(quietly)
Third time.

CAMILLE
(wrapping, too brightly)
He wants to know if I'm coming to Canarsie Sunday.

The phone buzzes again. A text. Camille reads it with one hand. Her face drains.

HARMONY
Camille?

CAMILLE
(beat, sliding the phone back, finishing the cast)
You're all done, chief. (to the boy) No basketball for six weeks, and don't stick a coat hanger down there when it itches.

The boy leaves with his mother. Camille stands at the sink, washing fiberglass resin off her hands, scrubbing much too long.

HARMONY
(beat)
What did he say?

CAMILLE
(beat, not turning, flat)
"I am coming to the hospital at one o'clock. (beat) We will talk about the kitchen."

14 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ON-CALL ROOM 2 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 11:21 AM

Arianna, on the bottom bunk, trying to read a review book with her eyes closing. The door opens. Raven comes in with a turkey sandwich and a carton of chocolate milk.

RAVEN
Eat this.

ARIANNA
(not looking up)
Not hungry.

RAVEN
(sitting on the bunk)
You haven't eaten since yesterday at four. (beat) I counted. (beat) Your hands were shaking holding a retractor for Elxa. She noticed. She sent me.

ARIANNA
(beat)
I have eleven days.

RAVEN
(opening the milk)
And you're going to spend them falling apart. (beat) Arianna. You've done eighteen hundred questions. (beat) You were three points short in October when you were sleeping four hours a night through a hurricane and a train crash. (beat) What you need now is not more. (beat) It's less.

Arianna looks at her. Something in her face finally gives.

ARIANNA
(barely)
If I fail again...

RAVEN
(beat)
Then I'll still be here. (beat) And you'll take it a third time. (beat) And I'll make a hundred more purple cards.

Arianna takes the sandwich. She eats half of it in four bites.

ARIANNA
(mouth full)
Today's your birthday-eve-eve.

RAVEN
(beat)
Don't.

ARIANNA
(beat)
They're planning something at the house. (beat) It's big. (beat) Marc ordered a cake from Make My Cake.

RAVEN
(horrified)
How big?

ARIANNA
(beat, chewing)
Much too much.

15 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - CONFERENCE ROOM B - DAY

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 11:44 AM

A small room, blinds drawn. Dolores Haskins, the administrator surveyor, sits behind a table with an interview form. Across from her, in his white coat, sits Kennerly.

HASKINS
(reading)
Dr. Kennerly. Surgical intern, PGY-1. (beat) You're on academic probation.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Yes, ma'am.

HASKINS
(beat)
For what?

KENNERLY
(beat)
Unprofessional conduct. (beat) I was cruel to a patient's family in September. (beat) I deserved it.

Haskins makes a note.

HASKINS
(beat)
We're interviewing residents about supervision and evaluation in this department. (beat) In your observation, has Dr. Marc-Anthony Bullock received preferential treatment because of his family?

A long beat. Kennerly looks down at his hands. It would be so easy.

KENNERLY
(finally)
No, ma'am.

HASKINS
(beat)
No?

KENNERLY
(beat, looking up)
I've wanted him to have. (beat) For five months, I've looked for it. I wanted it to be true so badly I told the whole cafeteria. (beat) He got the cases because he was ready for them. He got the compliments because he earned them. (beat) He's better than me. (beat) That's the only preferential treatment I've ever seen him get.

Haskins stops writing and looks at him.

HASKINS
(beat)
You told the cafeteria.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Yes, ma'am.

HASKINS
(beat)
How did you know?

Kennerly's jaw tightens. He thinks of a tea set with gold rims. He thinks of "We don't really know each other, do we?"

KENNERLY
(beat, quietly)
I'd like to answer that honestly, ma'am. (beat) But I think I need to talk to the hospital's lawyer first.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

16 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - GENERAL COUNSEL'S OFFICE - DAY

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 12:04 PM

A cramped office full of banker's boxes. Bassett sits behind his desk with his reading glasses on. Kennerly stands in front of it. He won't sit.

BASSETT
(beat)
You told a Joint Commission surveyor you needed a lawyer, Dr. Kennerly. (beat) Congratulations. (beat) You have the hospital's lawyer. (beat) Talk.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Dr. Whitlow told me. (beat) In September. In his office. Tea. (beat) He said a member of the board had shared something "in confidence." He said Bullock was the Chief's son, and Victor Donohue's grandson. (beat) He said it would be a shame if people didn't know.

BASSETT
(beat)
Did he tell you to repeat it?

KENNERLY
(beat)
He told me to make them wonder. (beat) Those words. (beat) He said he'd write my fellowship letter and talk to the program director about my probation. (beat) After the Joint Commission letter came, he told me we didn't know each other.

Bassett takes off his glasses.

BASSETT
(beat)
Will you put that in writing? Signed, dated, under penalty of perjury?

KENNERLY
(beat)
Yes, sir.

BASSETT
(beat)
Why? (beat) It doesn't save you. It ends any chance you had with the one ally you thought you had in this building.

Kennerly looks at the window for a long beat.

KENNERLY
(quietly)
Because a woman from Cambria Heights gave me a plate on Thanksgiving, sir. (beat) She didn't know who I was. (beat) I've been trying to figure out ever since what kind of man takes a plate like that and keeps lying.

Bassett looks at him for a long moment. Then he takes a legal pad out of the drawer and slides it across the desk with a pen.

17 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 4 - GALLERY - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 12:17 PM

The gallery, empty except for Dr. Albritton, who is closing her folder. Below, the room is being turned over. The door opens. Lowery comes in, still in his scrub cap, and sits two seats away from her.

DR. ALBRITTON
(not looking at him)
Dr. Lowery. (beat) Your intern did the operation.

LOWERY
(beat)
Yes, ma'am.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
You barely touched an instrument.

LOWERY
(beat)
I touched every decision. (beat) That's what supervision is, Doctor. (beat) It isn't my hands on the stapler. It's my eyes on his.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat, turning)
And if his last name were Kennerly?

LOWERY
(beat, evenly)
Then Dr. Kennerly would have been first assist on a perforated stomach in front of the Joint Commission, and I'd have watched him twice as hard. (beat) I'm fifty-eight years old, Dr. Albritton. I trained at Kings County under men who had to be perfect, because nobody would forgive them for being anything less. (beat) I don't do favors in an operating room. (beat) Favors kill people.

Albritton studies him. Then she writes something in her folder. This time, it's more than one word.

18 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - OR 7 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 12:31 PM

Geraldine Toomer, under anesthesia, her abdomen opened through a long vertical midline incision. Rising out of it is a huge, smooth, glistening gray cyst the size of a beach ball. Clayton and Raven work their hands gently around its sides.

CLAYTON
(calm)
We don't puncture it. (beat) Mucinous contents spill and seed the abdomen. (beat) Pseudomyxoma. (beat) It comes out whole or not at all.

ANESTHESIOLOGIST
(watching the monitor)
Tell me before you lift. (beat) When the weight comes off her vena cava, her pressure's going to drop.

CLAYTON
(to Raven)
You lift. (beat) Slowly. Like you're carrying a sleeping child.

Raven slides her hands under the cyst. Clayton clamps and divides the infundibulopelvic ligament. Raven lifts. It's impossibly heavy. Her arms shake. It rises out of the abdomen, inch by inch, and comes free.

ANESTHESIOLOGIST
(fast)
Pressure's eighty over forty. (beat) Fluids wide open. (beat) Seventy-eight. (beat) Ninety. (beat) She's coming back.

Raven sets the cyst into a basin held by the scrub nurse, who staggers. The circulator puts it on the scale.

CIRCULATOR
(staring)
Forty-one pounds, four ounces.

CLAYTON
(beat, softly)
That's a toddler. (beat) She's been carrying a toddler for two years, and her church thought she was just eating too much.

RAVEN
(beat, breathing hard)
She played the organ every Sunday with this.

CLAYTON
(beat, looking at her)
Happy early birthday, Dr. Ellison. (beat) Frozen section, please.

19 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MAIN LOBBY - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 1:01 PM

The revolving door. Augustin Toussaint, in his gray suit and an overcoat, comes in from the cold with his hat in his hand. Camille, in scrubs and her Saints jacket, waits by the information desk. Harmony stands at a distance by the elevators, her arms folded tight.

AUGUSTIN
(stiff)
Camille.

CAMILLE
(beat)
Papa. (beat) There's a chapel on two. (beat) It's quiet.

Augustin glances across the lobby at Harmony. A long beat. Then he follows his daughter to the elevator without looking back.

20 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - INTERFAITH CHAPEL - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 1:06 PM

A small chapel: six pews, a stained-glass window of abstract doves, a rack of votive candles. Augustin doesn't sit. He stands by the candles with his back to his daughter.

AUGUSTIN
(beat)
In the kitchen. (beat) Your head on her back.

CAMILLE
(beat)
Yes, Papa.

AUGUSTIN
(beat)
Your mother suspected. (beat) When you were sixteen. That girl from Ursuline. (beat) I told her she was imagining it.

CAMILLE
(beat)
She wasn't.

Augustin turns. His eyes are wet and furious at the same time.

AUGUSTIN
I have lost my hotel, Camille. My buildings. My city. Your mother's grave. (beat) I can't...

CAMILLE
(beat)
You can't what, Papa?

AUGUSTIN
(beat, his voice breaking)
I can't lose the daughter I thought I had. (beat) Not this year. (beat) It is too much. (beat) I am sixty-four years old and sleeping on a couch in Canarsie, and it is too much.

CAMILLE
(beat, standing very straight)
You're not losing anything, Papa. (beat) I'm the same girl who sat on your knee at the hotel bar and ate cherries out of the garnish tray. (beat) The only thing you lost is a lie. (beat) And I told it for you.

A long silence. Augustin picks up his hat.

AUGUSTIN
(beat, quietly)
Don't bring her to my table, Camille.

He walks out. Camille stands alone in the chapel among the votive candles.

21 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MEDICINE FLOOR - CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 1:32 PM

Whitlow, in his finest suit, sits across from Albritton and Mayfield. Mr. Tate's chart lies open between them. Dr. Grant stands against the wall.

WHITLOW
(smooth)
An unfortunate lapse by an ER nurse. (beat) She failed to transcribe the daughter's information. I'll speak to Emergency Nursing myself.

MAYFIELD
(mild)
The ER nurse wrote it down, Dr. Whitlow. (beat) On a triage note at nine-fourteen Tuesday morning. "Pt on home digoxin 0.25 daily per daughter." (beat) It's right here.

WHITLOW
(beat)
Then the admitting team missed it.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
The admitting team had no form that asked for it. (beat) Your department has no medication reconciliation process, Doctor. (beat) National Patient Safety Goal eight has been in effect since January. (beat) Your own policy says "implementation pending." (beat) That isn't a lapse by a nurse. It's a system. (beat) And it's yours.

Whitlow sits very still. Dr. Grant stares at the floor.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
It was a surgical intern who caught it. (beat) On a consult for a pacemaker.

WHITLOW
(beat, barely)
Which intern?

MAYFIELD
(checking his notes)
Dr. Amond Baker.

Whitlow closes his eyes for just a moment. Amond Baker lives in the house on 49th Avenue.

22 INT. MONTY'S ON JACKSON - BAR - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 1:51 PM

A quick lunch at the bar. Marc and Amond eat burgers. Monty (43) leans on the bar. Cedric (40) sits at the end with a crossword. Marc has a list on a napkin.

MARC
(reading)
Saturday. Seven o'clock. The roof deck, with heaters. (beat) The cake from Make My Cake, three tiers. Red velvet. (beat) A DJ, Cedric's friend. (beat) Gloria's coming. Elxa and Russell. Camille. (beat) And I was thinking...

AMOND
(chewing)
Raven said small.

MARC
(beat)
Raven's never had a birthday party. (beat) Ever. (beat) Her grandmother couldn't afford it, and her mother was... (beat) She told me in July. Twenty-five years, not one party.

MONTY
(beat)
What were you thinking?

MARC
(beat)
Lorna. (beat) Her mother. (beat) I could fly her up from Savannah Saturday morning. (beat) Surprise.

A beat. Amond puts down his burger.

AMOND
(flat)
No.

MARC
Amond...

AMOND
(beat)
She called her mother one week ago, Marc. (beat) For the first time in six years. (beat) That's hers. It's not yours to fix. (beat) You can't buy it. You can't fly it up from Savannah.

CEDRIC
(not looking up from the crossword)
Seven letters. "Too much of a good thing."

MONTY
(beat, to Marc)
Excess.

CEDRIC
(beat)
Doesn't fit. (beat) "A Donohue."

Monty laughs. Marc looks at the napkin. Then he takes a pen, crosses out the last line, and then the DJ, and then two of the three tiers.

MARC
(beat)
Small.

AMOND
(picking up his burger)
Small.

23 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - NURSES' STATION - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 2:17 PM

Elxa, on her stool, her feet up. Natasha comes down the hall between surveyor meetings, her suit immaculate, and stops beside her.

NATASHA
(low)
How are you?

ELXA
(beat)
Thirty weeks. Huge. (beat) Russell bought a birthing ball. It's purple. It's in our living room. (beat) He sits on it to grade lab reports.

NATASHA
(smiling)
Your father bought me a rocking chair. It took him four hours to put together. (beat) There was a screw left over. We never knew where it went. (beat) That chair rocked you, Marc and Grace.

ELXA
(beat)
How's it going, Mama?

NATASHA
(beat)
I don't know. (beat) They don't tell you. (beat) They watch you.

ELXA
(beat)
Daddy says Victor called you this morning.

NATASHA
(beat, dry)
Daddy offered to call "a man he knows at the Commission." (beat) I told him if he did, I'd have him barred from the building. (beat) He laughed for a full minute.

Bernie hurries up the hall.

BERNIE
(low)
Dr. Donohue. (beat) Dr. Albritton is asking for Dr. Bullock. (beat) The intern. (beat) Now. Conference Room B.

Natasha's face doesn't move. But her hand finds the edge of the counter.

NATASHA
(beat, evenly)
Then page him, Bernie. (beat) And don't tell me how it goes. (beat) I'm not allowed to know.

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

24 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL FLOOR - CONFERENCE ROOM B - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 2:41 PM

Marc sits across the table from Dr. Albritton. Haskins takes notes. Marc's hands are folded on the table, perfectly still.

DR. ALBRITTON
Dr. Bullock. (beat) On November ninth, you were removed from Cardiothoracic and OB/GYN rotations. (beat) Did you request that?

MARC
(beat)
No, ma'am. (beat) I asked my mother to reverse it. She said no.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
You asked the Chief of Surgery to reverse it.

MARC
(beat)
I asked my mother, at home, at the kitchen table. (beat) She said, "Talk to Dr. Lowery." (beat) Dr. Lowery said no.

Haskins makes a note.

DR. ALBRITTON
October twentieth. The Woodside train collision. (beat) You held Lorraine Fuller's descending aorta with your hand for several minutes in the trauma bay. (beat) Who was supervising you?

MARC
(beat)
Dr. Lowery, then Dr. Robert Bullock, when he arrived. (beat) It was a mass casualty. (beat) There were a hundred and four patients. (beat) Nobody was thinking about whose son I was. (beat) Mrs. Fuller died at eleven-oh-four. (beat) I called it.

Albritton looks at him over her half-moon glasses.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
I read your operative notes this morning. All of them. (beat) They're unusually thorough. (beat) Why?

MARC
(beat)
Because since November ninth, every word I write is going to be read by someone who wants to find something wrong with it. (beat) My sister told me to make them all clean. (beat) They were always clean, Doctor. (beat) Now they're just longer.

A flicker at the corner of Albritton's mouth. Then it's gone.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
One more question. Off the form. (beat) You're Victor Donohue's grandson. (beat) You could have done anything. Research. Policy. The Foundation. (beat) Why are you an intern taking the 7 train and holding retractors at four in the morning?

Marc thinks about it honestly.

MARC
(beat)
Because when my hands are inside somebody, ma'am, nobody in the room cares whose grandson I am. (beat) The patient only cares if I'm good. (beat) It's the only place in my life where that's true.

Albritton closes her folder.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
Thank you, Dr. Bullock. That's all.

25 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - SURGICAL ICU - BED 4 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 3:12 PM

Jermaine, post-op, an NG tube in his nose and a feeding tube in his belly, pale but awake. Annette sits beside him in her corrections uniform. Esther checks his drains.

ESTHER
You lost about a third of your stomach, Mr. Biggs. (beat) It'll stretch back over time. (beat) But no more contests. (beat) Ever.

JERMAINE
(hoarse)
Yes, ma'am.

ANNETTE
(sharp)
Tell her why.

JERMAINE
(beat)
Ma.

ANNETTE
(beat)
Tell her why you eat a hundred and seventy-four chicken wings on a Wednesday night.

JERMAINE
(beat, looking away)
Twenty-five hundred dollars. (beat) First prize. (beat) Ma works doubles at Rikers. She's been doing doubles since Daddy left in '91. (beat) I've won four contests this year. (beat) I paid her car note. I paid the light bill in August.

Annette's face crumples.

ANNETTE
(beat)
I never asked you to.

JERMAINE
(beat)
You never asked anybody for anything, Ma. (beat) That's why.

Esther quietly steps back from the bed. She thinks of Corinne Smilley cleaning offices for twenty years with five daughters, and a boy from Roxbury who ate at her table.

26 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - MEDICINE FLOOR - ROOM 714 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 3:34 PM

Ambrose Tate sits up now, alert, his heart rate a steady sixty-four, eating a cup of applesauce. Celestine is at his side. Amond is checking the monitor.

AMBROSE
(pointing his spoon at Amond)
Celestine. This is the young man. (beat) The one who saw the yellow.

CELESTINE
(standing, taking Amond's hand in both of hers)
Dr. Baker. (beat) I wrote it down. I told them. (beat) And nobody heard me until you.

AMOND
(beat)
You did everything right, Ms. Tate-Moore. (beat) The system didn't.

CELESTINE
(beat)
I'm a bank manager, Doctor. (beat) If I lost track of a customer's money between two windows, they'd shut my branch down. (beat) This is my father.

AMOND
(beat, quietly)
I know. (beat) That's why they're here.

Ambrose, chewing his applesauce, looks out the window at the gray December sky.

AMBROSE
(beat)
Fifty years ago today, they arrested that lady in Montgomery. (beat) I was carrying bags on the Broadway Limited out of Chicago. (beat) A porter in Montgomery called us on the line that night. (beat) He said, "She's sitting down, and she isn't getting up." (beat) We all knew what it meant.

AMOND
(beat)
What did it mean, sir?

AMBROSE
(beat, smiling)
That too much is too much, son. (beat) And somebody finally said so.

27 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - GYNECOLOGY RECOVERY - DAY

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 3:52 PM

Geraldine Toomer wakes. A nurse raises the head of the bed. Raven stands at the foot of it. Geraldine looks down. For the first time in eighteen months, past the flat white sheet, she can see her feet. She wiggles her toes. She begins to cry.

GERALDINE
(whispering)
There they are. (beat) Lord. There they are.

RAVEN
(smiling)
Frozen section's benign, Ms. Toomer. (beat) Mucinous cystadenoma. (beat) No cancer.

GERALDINE
(beat)
How much?

RAVEN
(beat)
Forty-one pounds, four ounces.

Geraldine laughs, wincing, holding her incision.

GERALDINE
(beat)
Sister Patterson told the whole choir I was eating too many fellowship dinners. (beat) I'm going to sit in the front pew Sunday in my tightest dress. (beat) And then I'm going to play "Total Praise" so loud she'll need her hearing aid.

RAVEN
(beat)
Ms. Toomer. (beat) Your hair. (beat) After two days in a hospital bed. (beat) Can I fix it for you before Sunday?

GERALDINE
(touching her head, startled)
You do hair? (beat) And surgery?

RAVEN
(beat)
I did hair first. (beat) Surgery is just hair with a scalpel.

28 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ON-CALL ROOM 2 - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 4:07 PM

Arianna, rested, sits at the ancient desktop computer in the corner with a pencil in her teeth. On the screen: "NBME PRACTICE ASSESSMENT -- SCORE REPORT." She has just finished. She clicks. It loads, one line at a time. She takes the pencil out of her mouth. The predicted score is twenty-one points above passing.

She stares at it. Then she picks up her phone and dials.

ARIANNA
(into the phone, flat)
Ellison. (beat) Twenty-one over. (beat) The practice one. (beat) After a sandwich and four hours of sleep. (beat) Shut up. (beat) Shut up, Raven, don't you dare say "less." (beat) ...Okay. (beat) Okay, you were right. (beat) Don't tell anybody I said that.

She hangs up. She sits back in the chair, and for the first time in weeks her shoulders come down from her ears.

29 EXT. GANTRY PLAZA STATE PARK - PIER - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 4:31 PM

Late afternoon, the light already failing. The Pepsi-Cola sign is lit red against the darkening river. Camille sits at the end of the pier in her Saints jacket, staring at Manhattan. Harmony sits down beside her with two coffees and doesn't say anything.

CAMILLE
(finally)
"Don't bring her to my table."

HARMONY
(quietly)
I heard. (beat) From the hall.

CAMILLE
(beat)
He lost forty buildings, Harmony. (beat) And he's going to choose to lose me too. (beat) On purpose. (beat) Because that's the one thing he can still control.

Harmony sets the coffees down on the boards.

HARMONY
(beat)
My daddy has a nodule in his lung. (beat) Six millimeters. The CT is next Thursday. (beat) He's been coughing for four months, and he jokes about it. (beat) I'm so scared I can't sleep. (beat) I'd give anything to know he'll still be at my table in ten years. (beat) Your daddy is going to come back, Camille. (beat) He's just not there yet.

CAMILLE
(turning to her)
You never told me about your father.

HARMONY
(beat)
You never told me about yours either, until today.

Camille leans against her. Harmony puts an arm around her. They sit on the end of the pier while the lights come up across the river.

30 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - CHIEF'S OFFICE - DAY
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 4:48 PM

Natasha at the window. Bassett comes in and closes the door behind him. He holds a manila envelope, sealed with red tape.

BASSETT
(beat)
Bryce Kennerly. (beat) A signed, sworn statement. (beat) Horace told him in September, in his office, over the good tea. (beat) "Make them wonder." (beat) He promised a fellowship letter and help with his probation.

Natasha turns slowly.

NATASHA
(beat)
Why would Kennerly do that?

BASSETT
(beat)
He said Lillian Divine gave him a plate on Thanksgiving. (beat) I've practiced law for twenty-two years, Natasha. I've never heard a better reason.

Natasha takes the envelope. She weighs it in her hand. Everything she needs to destroy Horace Whitlow, in a manila envelope.

BASSETT
(beat)
The board meets on the fifteenth. (beat) With this, he's done.

NATASHA
(beat)
Seal it, Franklin.

BASSETT
Natasha...

NATASHA
(handing it back)
Put it in the safe. (beat) Not because I'm merciful. (beat) Because the day I use it, I become him. (beat) And because one day, Horace is going to make his next move. (beat) And I'd like to still have one left.

Bassett looks at her with something close to awe. The phone rings. Bernie's voice comes over the intercom.

BERNIE (V.O.)
(on the intercom)
Dr. Donohue. (beat) Dr. Albritton is ready for the exit conference. (beat) Five-thirty. The boardroom. (beat) She asked that Dr. Whitlow attend.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

31 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - BOARDROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 5:31 PM

The long mahogany table. Portraits of past Chiefs on the walls. Natasha at one side with Bassett and Bernie. Whitlow across from her, immaculate, his hands folded. The CEO, the Chief Nursing Officer and the program director. At the head: Dr. Albritton, Mayfield and Haskins.

DR. ALBRITTON
(reading from her summary)
This for-cause survey was conducted in response to a complaint alleging conflicts of interest in the supervision and evaluation of a resident physician related to hospital leadership. (beat) We conducted three patient tracers, interviewed nineteen staff members, and reviewed one hundred and nine surgical cases.

Whitlow's eyes don't leave her.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
The complaint is not substantiated. (beat) Supervision and evaluation of the resident in question were appropriate, well documented, and, in the surveyors' judgment, exemplary. (beat) The Department of Surgery's November ninth service firewall is noted as a leading practice. (beat) We also observed full compliance with the Universal Protocol, including a model time-out, in the operating room this morning.

Natasha doesn't move. Bernie, beside her, closes her eyes.

DR. ALBRITTON
(turning a page)
However. (beat) A tracer on the Department of Medicine identified a patient who received duplicate digoxin therapy for approximately forty-eight hours, due to the absence of a medication reconciliation process. (beat) National Patient Safety Goal eight. (beat) The toxicity was identified by a surgical intern on consult, and the patient has recovered. (beat) This is a Requirement for Improvement for the Department of Medicine. (beat) Evidence of Standards Compliance is due within forty-five days.

Every head at the table turns, very slowly, toward Whitlow.

WHITLOW
(evenly)
The Department of Medicine will comply in full, Dr. Albritton.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat, looking at him over her glasses)
I'm sure it will, Dr. Whitlow. (beat) Complaints often take us places the complainant didn't expect. (beat) That's rather the point of having us come.

She closes her folder.

32 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - EXECUTIVE CORRIDOR - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 5:54 PM

The meeting is breaking up. Whitlow walks fast down the carpeted hall. Natasha comes out of the boardroom behind him.

NATASHA
Horace.

He stops and turns.

WHITLOW
(low, controlled)
You pointed them at Medicine.

NATASHA
(beat)
I never said the word "Medicine" in front of any of them. Ask Dr. Albritton. (beat) I opened every door in this hospital, Horace. (beat) You're the one who invited them in.

WHITLOW
(beat)
Your son's roommate. (beat) Baker. (beat) Of all the interns in this building.

NATASHA
(beat)
Amond Baker caught a fatal medication error on your floor that your own residents missed for two days. (beat) You should send him a fruit basket.

Whitlow looks at her. For the first time in six months, he has nothing to say.

NATASHA
(beat, quieter)
You wanted them to wonder about my son, Horace. (beat) Now they're going to wonder about you. (beat) That isn't revenge. (beat) That's just the truth, catching up.

She walks past him. He stands alone in the long corridor under the portraits of the past Chiefs.

33 INT. QUEENS GRACE HOSPITAL - ELEVATOR - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 6:03 PM

Marc, in his coat, steps into the elevator. Dr. Albritton is already there with her rolling briefcase. The doors close. A long beat.

MARC
(carefully)
Dr. Albritton.

DR. ALBRITTON
(eyes on the numbers)
Dr. Bullock. (beat) I'm not permitted to discuss the findings with you.

MARC
(beat)
I understand.

The elevator descends. Four. Three.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat, still looking at the numbers)
In 1971, I was the only Black woman in my class at Meharry who wanted to be a surgeon. (beat) A professor told me I'd be better suited to pediatrics. "Gentler hands." (beat) I became an internist instead, out of spite, and I've regretted it for thirty years.

Marc looks at her.

DR. ALBRITTON
(beat)
Your hands are your own, Dr. Bullock. (beat) Don't let anyone, a professor, a rival or a grandfather, tell you otherwise.

The doors open on the lobby. She rolls her briefcase out and doesn't look back.

34 INT. CLAYTON'S SUBLET - BROOKLYN HEIGHTS - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 7:12 PM

Clayton cooks pasta in the galley kitchen. Esther sits on the sofa with her phone in her lap. More of her things are here now: a second box, her books on the shelf, her white coat on the hook beside his.

ESTHER
(beat)
I want to go home for Christmas. (beat) To Mattapan. (beat) Both of us.

CLAYTON
(stirring, carefully)
Okay.

ESTHER
(beat)
And I'm going to ask my mother to invite Malcolm.

Clayton stops stirring. He turns.

CLAYTON
(beat)
Esther.

ESTHER
(beat)
A boy from Roxbury ate at my mother's table for twenty-seven years because his own parents wouldn't feed him. (beat) I saw a man today who ate a hundred and seventy-four wings to pay his mother's light bill. (beat) And I thought, Malcolm was always eating to pay for something. (beat) I'm not forgiving him. (beat) I'm just not going to be the reason there's an empty chair.

CLAYTON
(beat, barely)
Is that too much?

ESTHER
(beat)
Probably. (beat) Dr. Greenidge will have a field day. (beat) Ask me again on Christmas Eve.

Clayton turns back to the stove. His hand is shaking slightly on the spoon.

35 INT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - KITCHEN - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 7:43 PM

Raven comes in from the cold, exhausted. Marc, Amond and Arianna sit at the kitchen table, looking suspiciously innocent. On the counter: a stack of mail. On top, a small

square envelope in a careful hand she now recognizes. "L. ELLISON, MLK JR. BLVD., SAVANNAH, GA."

Raven picks it up. She looks at the others. Then she opens it, right there in the kitchen, the first letter she hasn't put in the shoebox. A birthday card. A cartoon cake.

RAVEN
(reading aloud, her voice catching)
"Happy 26th birthday, my Raven. (beat) Twenty-six years ago Saturday, I held you in Memorial Hospital and promised I'd be better. (beat) I wasn't, for a long time. (beat) I am now. (beat) If it's not too much, I'd like to see you. Christmas, or whenever you say. (beat) If it's too much, I understand. (beat) Mama."

Silence in the kitchen. Raven sets the card down on the counter.

MARC
(beat, carefully)
Rave. (beat) I have to tell you something. (beat) Today at lunch, I almost bought her a plane ticket. (beat) For Saturday. (beat) A surprise.

Raven turns to look at him.

AMOND
(dry)
I stopped him.

MARC
(beat)
Amond stopped me. (beat) Because it's yours. (beat) I'm sorry I even thought it.

Raven looks at Marc for a long moment. Then she crosses the kitchen and hugs him hard.

RAVEN
(into his shoulder)
Thank you for not. (beat) And thank you for almost.

ARIANNA
(beat)
So what are you going to tell her?

Raven picks up a pen from the counter, turns the card over and writes one word on the back of an envelope. She holds it up. "CHRISTMAS."

36 INT. CAMILLE'S APARTMENT - JACKSON HEIGHTS - BEDROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 9:26 PM

The bedroom, lit by a single lamp and the streetlight through the blinds. The cast-iron pot sits clean on the stove in the next room. Camille and Harmony sit on the edge of the bed, close, their shoulders touching.

CAMILLE
(beat)
You can still go home, Choir. (beat) Today was a lot.

HARMONY
(beat)
Today was much too much.

CAMILLE
(beat, quietly)
Yeah.

HARMONY
(beat, turning to her)
So let's have one thing tonight that's just enough.

Camille looks at her. Then she reaches over and turns off the lamp. In the dark, the sound of two women laughing softly at nothing. Then not laughing.

37 INT. ELXA AND RUSSELL'S HOUSE - ST. ALBANS - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 10:14 PM

A cozy two-family house. Stacks of graded chemistry labs on the coffee table. Elxa, in pajamas, sits on an enormous purple birthing ball, bouncing gently, eyes closed. Russell, on the floor beside her, times her breathing with his wristwatch like a man running a titration.

RUSSELL
(counting)
In, two, three, four. (beat) Out, two, three, four. (beat) Elxa. (beat) You're doing it wrong.

ELXA
(eyes still closed)
I'm a surgeon, Russell.

RUSSELL
(beat)
And I'm the chemistry teacher, so I know a reaction when I see one. (beat) You're holding your breath at the top.

Elxa opens her eyes. She breathes out. All the way. Something in her shoulders lets go.

ELXA
(beat)
The Joint Commission cleared Marc today. (beat) Mama called. (beat) She cried. On the phone. To me. (beat) She hasn't cried on the phone to me since my wedding.

RUSSELL
(beat, putting a hand on her belly)
And this one?

ELXA
(beat)
Thirty weeks. (beat) Kicking like he wants out.

RUSSELL
(beat)
Tell him February. (beat) Super Bowl. (beat) We'll have the TV on.

ELXA
(beat, laughing)
You're not watching football while I'm in labor.

RUSSELL
(beat)
Watch me.

38 INT. NATASHA AND ROBERT'S BROWNSTONE - RIVERSIDE DRIVE - BEDROOM - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 10:41 PM

Natasha sits on the edge of the bed in her robe, her pearls off. Robert comes in with two cups of tea and sits beside her.

ROBERT
(beat)
Elxa says you cried on the phone.

NATASHA
(beat)
I did not cry. I was moved.

ROBERT
(beat)
Tasha.

NATASHA
(beat, taking the tea)
Franklin has a signed statement from Bryce Kennerly. (beat) It says Horace planted the rumor. (beat) I told him to put it in the safe.

Robert stares at her.

ROBERT
(beat)
You have Horace Whitlow's head in an envelope, and you put it in a safe.

NATASHA
(beat)
Daddy would have used it tonight. (beat) Daddy would have had Horace on a plane to a hospital in Duluth by Monday. (beat) I don't want to be Daddy, Robert. (beat) I just want to be good enough that I never have to be.

Robert puts his arm around her.

ROBERT
(beat)
You already are. (beat) That's what scares Horace.

39 INT. MTA QUEENS VILLAGE DEPOT - QUEENS VILLAGE - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 11:14 PM

A cavernous bus depot, rows of blue-and-white buses under the sodium lights. Howard Divine's Q4 pulls into its berth. He shuts off the engine. The bus is empty. He walks to the first seat behind his own and unties the black ribbon. He folds it carefully, the way you fold a flag.

He coughs. Deep, wet, long. He sits down in the seat for a moment, catching his breath, the folded ribbon in his

hands.

MARC (V.O.)
A surgeon learns that there's such a thing as too much.

Howard puts the ribbon in his breast pocket, over his heart. He gets up and walks out of the depot into the cold.

TAG

40 INT. MONTY'S ON JACKSON - BAR - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 11:36 PM

Late. A few regulars. Kennerly sits alone at the end of the bar with a beer. Marc comes in, takes the stool beside him and nods to Monty, who slides him a beer.

KENNERLY
(not looking at him)
I'm not apologizing.

MARC
(beat)
I know.

KENNERLY
(beat)
Haskins told Lowery what I said. (beat) Lowery told Elxa. (beat) Elxa told me I'm still on probation, and to get out of her sight. (beat) She almost smiled.

MARC
(beat)
Lillian's plate?

KENNERLY
(beat)
Don't.

Marc raises his bottle. A beat. Kennerly, without looking at him, clinks his own bottle against it.

MONTY
(wiping a glass, to nobody)
A vault with a tap. (beat) I didn't see a thing.

41 EXT. THE HOUSE ON 49TH AVENUE - STOOP - NIGHT
THURSDAY, DECEMBER 1, 2005 - 11:58 PM

Marc on the stoop, his breath visible in the cold. Upstairs, Raven's light is on. Her shadow on the blind holds the birthday card. Across the river, the Manhattan skyline.

MARC (V.O.)
Too much blood. Too much pressure. Too much medicine.

Down the block, a Q-line bus passes on Vernon, almost empty, lit up from inside like a lantern.

MARC (V.O.)
But nobody tells you about the other kind. (beat) Too much love. Too much hope. Too much history in one house.

Raven's light goes off.

MARC (V.O.)
Fifty years ago tonight, a seamstress in Montgomery decided that too much was too much, and sat down. (beat) And that turned out to be just enough.

Marc stands, takes one last look at the skyline, and goes inside. The door closes.

FADE OUT.

END OF EPISODE

Media Companion: Episode 2x10

Off-screen media around the episode, in chronological order. Not counted in page length (MA-009 §5).

THE NEW YORK TIMES: "50 YEARS LATER, A SEAT LEFT EMPTY IN HER HONOR"

Thursday, December 1, 2005

"Fifty years ago today, Rosa Parks refused to give up her seat on a Montgomery city bus... Transit systems across the country planned to mark the anniversary today by reserving seats in her memory, five weeks after her death at 92..."

ASSOCIATED PRESS: "VIRGINIA GOVERNOR SPARES INMATE; NATION'S 1,000TH EXECUTION NOW SET FOR NORTH CAROLINA" / "TRANSIT UNION, MTA FAR APART AS DEADLINE NEARS"

Thursday, December 1, 2005

"RICHMOND, Va. (AP) -- Gov. Mark Warner commuted the death sentence of Robin Lovitt on Tuesday..." / "NEW YORK (AP) -- The Transport Workers Union and the MTA remained far apart on wages and pensions with the contract set to expire December 16..."

The Joint Commission: Summary of Survey Findings (excerpt)

Queens Grace Hospital, for-cause survey, December 1, 2005

"Complaint: alleged conflict of interest in supervision and evaluation of a resident physician. FINDING: NOT SUBSTANTIATED. Supervision and evaluation appropriate and well documented. Department of Surgery service-assignment firewall (11/9/2005) noted as a leading practice. Universal Protocol: full compliance observed."

"REQUIREMENT FOR IMPROVEMENT -- Department of Medicine: NPSG Goal 8 (accurately and completely reconcile medications across the continuum of care). Tracer patient received duplicate digoxin therapy for approximately 48 hours. Evidence of Standards Compliance due within 45 days."

QueensGraceConfidential (Blogger)

Thursday, December 1, 2005, 7:02 PM

"THE INSPECTORS HAVE LEFT THE BUILDING. Sources in the boardroom say the complaint against Dr. X was NOT SUBSTANTIATED (we told you). The twist: they found a real problem, in MEDICINE. A man got double heart pills for two days, and guess who caught it? Dr. X's roommate. A certain Chief of Medicine reportedly 'has no comment.' Also: a 41-pound tumor came out in OR 7 today, and a man ate 174 wings and lost a third of his stomach. Thursday, people." Comments (2,071).

Birthday card: Lorna Ellison to Raven Ellison

Postmarked Savannah, Ga., November 28, 2005

"Happy 26th birthday, my Raven. Twenty-six years ago Saturday, I held you in Memorial Hospital and promised I'd be better. I wasn't, for a long time. I am now. If it's not too much, I'd like to see you. Christmas, or whenever you say. If it's too much, I understand. -Mama" (Raven's reply, written on an envelope: "CHRISTMAS.")

SMS, Motorola RAZR (Arianna Cummings to Raven Ellison)

Thursday, December 1, 2005, 4:09 PM

Arianna: "21 over."

Arianna: "dont say it"

Raven: "less."

Arianna: "i hate you. k."

Continuity Sheet: Episode 2x10

New Canon Established

- **THE JOINT COMMISSION FOR-CAUSE SURVEY** (unannounced, December 1, 2005): Dr. Constance Albritton (physician surveyor), Gerald Mayfield, RN, and Dolores Haskins, using tracer methodology. They ran three tracers, interviewed 19 staff and reviewed 109 surgical cases. **Result: the complaint is NOT SUBSTANTIATED.** Marc's supervision was 'exemplary,' the Firewall was noted as a leading practice, and the OR showed full Universal Protocol compliance. **The Department of Medicine received a Requirement for Improvement** (NPSG Goal 8, medication reconciliation) after the Ambrose Tate digoxin error, with Evidence of Standards Compliance due within 45 days. Albritton: 'Complaints often take us places the complainant didn't expect.'
- **Amond caught the error** (xanthopsia, bradycardia of 38, a level of 4.1, treated with Digibind) on a pacemaker consult. Harriet made him recite his grandmother's medicine cabinet every Sunday at age ten. **Whitlow's own department is now the one under scrutiny**, and the catch came from a 49th Avenue housemate. Natasha told Whitlow: 'You should send him a fruit basket.'
- **KENNERLY'S SWORN STATEMENT** to Bassett says Whitlow told him in September, in his office over tea, that Marc is the Chief's son and Victor's grandson ('from a board member in confidence'). Whitlow said 'make them wonder,' promised a fellowship letter and probation help, and later disowned him. Kennerly's reason: Lillian Divine's Thanksgiving plate. He told surveyor Haskins that Marc received no preferential treatment ('He's better than me'). **Natasha had the statement sealed in the General Counsel's safe** and won't use it at the December 15 board meeting: 'The day I use it, I become him... I'd like to still have one left.' Robert knows. Kennerly remains on probation, and he and Marc shared a beer at Monty's.
- **Marc's interview with Albritton:** he asked Natasha to reverse the Firewall at the kitchen table, and she sent him to Lowery, who said no. 'When my hands are inside somebody, nobody in the room cares whose grandson I am.' Albritton (Meharry, 1971) was steered away from surgery toward 'gentler hands' and became an internist out of spite. To Marc: 'Your hands are your own.' Lowery to Albritton: 'Favors kill people.' Lowery trained at Kings County.
- **Camille and Augustin:** in the chapel, Augustin confirmed he saw them in the kitchen. Camille's mother suspected when Camille was 16 ('that girl from Ursuline'). Augustin: 'Don't bring her to my table.' He does not accept it, per MA-005. **Harmony and Camille spent their first night together** at Camille's apartment. Harmony told Camille about Howard's nodule. Camille hadn't known about her father until today.
- **Raven's mother:** Lorna's birthday card asks to visit 'Christmas, or whenever you say.' **Raven answered 'CHRISTMAS.'** Marc almost flew Lorna up for a surprise party, and Amond stopped him. Raven's birthday (Saturday, December 3) will be a **small** roof-deck party with a one-tier red velvet cake from Make My Cake. Raven has never had a birthday party. Raven does Geraldine Toomer's hair.
- **Arianna:** she was sleeping three hours a night with 11 days to go. Raven locked her flashcards away and fed her. Her practice NBME came back **21 points above passing**. The retake is

December 12. Raven: 'less.'

- **Esther** wants to go to Mattapan for Christmas with Clayton, and **she will ask Corinne to invite Malcolm**: 'I'm not forgiving him. I'm just not going to be the reason there's an empty chair.' Clayton is shaken. More of Esther's things are now at Remsen Street.
- **Elxa (30 weeks):** Lamaze starts Monday, December 5. Russell bought a purple birthing ball and coaches her breathing. Russell: 'Tell him February. Super Bowl.' (Tuck is born on Super Bowl Sunday, February 5, 2006, per MA-005.) Natasha cried on the phone to Elxa for the first time since Elxa's wedding. Robert's rocking chair had one leftover screw. Victor offered to call 'a man he knows at the Commission,' and Natasha threatened to bar him from the building.
- **Howard Divine** tied a black ribbon on the seat behind him on the Q4 for the Rosa Parks anniversary and kept it in his breast pocket. His cough persists, and the CT is on Thursday, December 8.

Knowledge Tracker (as of December 1, 2005)

Item	Who knows
Whitlow planted the rumor (Kennerly's statement)	Kennerly, Bassett, Natasha, Robert; sealed in the GC's safe
JC findings	Leadership, the board (formal report), everyone (via the blog)
Harmony and Camille	Housemates, Augustin (confirmed, rejecting), Grace (likely)
Lorna visiting at Christmas	Raven, Marc, Amond, Arianna
Esther will invite Malcolm to Christmas	Esther, Clayton
Heir designation	Still secret: Victor, Marc, V.J., the Foundation board, Natasha and Joan

Patient Registry

Patient	DOB / age	Diagnosis	Procedure / surgeon	Outcome
Jermaine 'Jaws' Biggs	8/20/1978 (27)	Acute gastric dilatation after an eating contest (174 wings), necrosis and perforation	NG decompression; laparotomy, wedge resection of the greater curvature, washout, feeding jejunostomy (Lowery; Bullock; Smilley)	Recovering; no more contests
Ambrose Tate	7/4/1926 (79)	Digoxin toxicity (level 4.1) from home plus hospital digoxin; no med reconciliation	Digoxin immune fab (Baker; Medicine)	Recovered; HR 64
Geraldine Toomer	6/25/1953 (52)	34 x 29 cm ovarian mucinous cystadenoma, 41 lb 4 oz	Laparotomy, intact removal (Hartwell; Ellison)	Benign; she can see her feet
Teen forearm fracture	-	Forearm fracture	Fiberglass cast (Toussaint; Divine)	Discharged

New Characters

- **Dr. Constance Albritton** (b. September 8, 1946; Meharry), **Gerald Mayfield, RN** (b. May 19, 1954) and **Dolores Haskins** (b. January 27, 1959): Joint Commission surveyors. **Miss Odell**

Brightwater (b. April 22, 1927), a Q4 rider.

- **Jermaine Biggs** (b. August 20, 1978), the 2005 Sutphin Boulevard 'Wing King,' and his mother **Annette** (b. November 3, 1953), a Rikers corrections officer. **Ambrose Tate** (b. July 4, 1926), who carried bags for 41 years on the Twentieth Century Limited and the Broadway Limited, and his daughter **Celestine Tate-Moore** (b. October 18, 1955). **Geraldine Toomer** (b. June 25, 1953), organist at Greater Allen A.M.E.

Real-World Accuracy Notes

- December 1, 2005 was the 50th anniversary of Rosa Parks's arrest on a Cleveland Avenue bus in Montgomery (she died October 24, 2005). Transit agencies marked it by reserving seats in her honor. On November 29, 2005, Virginia Gov. Mark Warner commuted Robin Lovitt's death sentence, so the nation's 1,000th execution since 1976 fell to North Carolina (Kenneth Lee Boyd, December 2). The TWU Local 100 contract expired December 16, 2005, and the strike began December 20. The Pennsylvania Railroad's Broadway Limited and the New York Central's 20th Century Limited were famous Pullman trains. 'Total Praise' is by Richard Smallwood (1996).
- The Joint Commission: tracer methodology began in 2004 ('Shared Visions-New Pathways'). For-cause unannounced surveys respond to complaints. National Patient Safety Goal 8 (medication reconciliation) took effect in 2005, with full implementation expected by January 2006. A Requirement for Improvement requires Evidence of Standards Compliance within 45 days. The Universal Protocol (time-out) took effect July 2004.
- Medicine: acute gastric dilatation after binge eating can cause ischemic necrosis and perforation, and needs NG decompression and resection if necrotic. Digoxin toxicity causes nausea, confusion, bradyarrhythmias and xanthopsia (yellow vision), and is treated with digoxin immune fab. Mucinous cystadenomas can grow to massive size and should be removed intact to avoid spillage (pseudomyxoma peritonei). Relieving vena caval compression can cause abrupt hemodynamic shifts.